Avoiding AI Writing Tells

name	human
description	Use this skill whenever writing or editing prose meant to read as natural, human, professional, or encyclopedic: essays, reports, articles, LinkedIn/bio content, Wikipedia-style writing, academic papers, or any long-form text a person will present as their own or publish externally. Also use it as a review pass when asked to "make this sound less AI," "tighten this up," "make it sound more human," or to check a draft for generic, bloated, or formulaic writing.

A checklist of patterns that make writing read as generic, bloated, or obviously LLM-generated, and how to avoid or strip them out. Apply this both when *drafting* new prose and when *reviewing* someone else's draft (e.g., a student essay, a bio, a report).

The underlying failure mode: LLMs regress to the statistical mean. Specific, unusual, nuanced facts get smoothed into generic, confident-sounding statements. The fix is always the same: replace the generic claim with the specific one, or cut it.

Quick self-check before finalizing any piece of writing

Scan the draft and ask: does it contain any of the following? If yes, cut or rewrite.

1. Puffed-up "significance" language

Watch for: *stands as a testament to, plays a pivotal/crucial role, underscores its significance, marks a shift, symbolizing its enduring legacy, reflects broader trends, contributing to the evolving landscape, sets the stage for, key turning point.*

→ Fix: state the concrete fact. Cut the significance-claim entirely unless you can name *specifically* why/to whom it matters.

2. Canned "notability" / attribution padding

Watch for: *independent coverage, featured in [outlet], maintains an active social media presence, has been profiled by...*

→ Fix: only mention coverage/sources if it's actually load-bearing for the point being made.

3. Superficial analysis tacked onto sentence ends

Watch for present-participle add-ons: "*...fostering community engagement,*" "*...highlighting its importance,*" "*...ensuring long-term success.*"

→ Fix: delete the participial clause, or replace with a real, specific consequence.

4. Vague-authority attribution (weasel wording)

Watch for: *industry reports suggest, experts argue, observers have cited, some critics argue* (when only 1-2 sources actually exist), or "such as" lists implying more examples than are actually documented.

→ Fix: name the actual source, or drop the claim.

5. Outline-like "Challenges and Future Directions" boilerplate

Watch for a formulaic close: "Despite its [positives], X faces several challenges, including... Despite these challenges, X continues to..."

→ Fix: only include a challenges/future section if there's real, specific content, not a generic hedge-then-praise pattern.

6. Negative parallelisms

Watch for: "*not just X, but Y,*" "*It's not about A, it's about B,*" "*that's not X, that's Y,*" "*You're not just X, you're Y.*"

The "it's not X, it's Y" frame is currently the most recognizable single tell. Readers notice it fast, and the damage multiplies when it repeats: stacked pairs ("It's not written by humans, it's written by AI. It's not useful, it's slop.") or the version with a dash and a dramatic reveal ("That's not illusion — that's power"). It also turns up in speech now (video essays, presentations), so read spoken scripts and talk outlines for it too.

→ Fix: state Y directly and drop the denied X, unless someone actually believed X and the correction matters. Allow at most one such contrast in a piece, never two in a row.

7. The rule of three (triads)

Unedited AI writing reaches for groups of exactly three far more often than people do. The triplet sounds complete and rhythmic, so the model uses it whether or not there are really three things to say. Two forms:

- **The comma list.** "Item A, item B, and item C," usually with the Oxford comma, repeated sentence after sentence.
- **The triad of parallel words.** Three adjectives, verbs or short clauses stacked for punch: "Our tool is efficient, reliable, and secure." "We plan, build, and deliver." Often the three words overlap in meaning, or the third is filler added to complete the rhythm.

The tell is frequency and fit. One list of three is normal. Three or more triplets in a paragraph, or a triplet where the items are vague near-synonyms, reads as generated.

→ Fix: count the real items. If there are two, write two. If one carries the point, keep that one and give it a specific detail ("encrypts files at rest" instead of "secure"). If there really are three, keep them but vary the shape of nearby sentences so the paragraph doesn't fall into a one-two-three rhythm. Don't swap triplets for pairs or quads everywhere either; a forced pattern of any length is still a pattern.

8. Overused "AI vocabulary"

Words to flag and usually cut or replace with a plainer synonym: `delve, boasts (=has), bolstered, crucial, emphasizing, enduring, enhance, fostering, garner, highlight (verb), interplay, intricate/intricacies, key (adj), landscape (abstract), meticulous(ly), pivotal, robust, showcase, tapestry (abstract), testament, underscore (verb), valuable, vibrant, align with, encompassing, cultivating.*

→ Fix: prefer the plain word: *used* not *utilized*, *died* not *passed away*, *tried* not *attempted*, *moved* not *relocated*, *wrote* not *authored*. Simple "is/has" phrasing is a good human-sounding default, not something to avoid.

9. Avoidance of plain "is / has" constructions

Watch for constructions replacing a simple copula: "*serves as,*" "*stands as,*" "*represents a,*" "*marks the,*" "*boasts a,*" "*offers a*" where "is" or "has" would do.

→ Fix: use the plain verb. "The gallery is LAAA's exhibition space" beats "The gallery serves as LAAA's exhibition space."

10. Formatting tells (mostly for documents; the em-dash and emoji points apply to chat prose too)

- Title-case section headings ("Impact Of Technology And Digitalization")
- Overuse of **boldface** for emphasis, especially inline-bold list headers ("**Durability**: Unlike roasted meats...")
- Em dashes used constantly, especially with spaces around them, where a comma/colon/parenthesis would be more natural. Readers now treat the em dash as a telltale sign on its own. The worst form is the editorializing tail, where a dash adds a verdict or flourish to a sentence that was already complete.
- Emoji used as bullets or status markers, especially green check marks and red X marks, or emoji at the start of headings in text that is not casual chat
- Markdown syntax leaking into non-Markdown output (asterisks for bold in wikitext, `##` headers, curly smart quotes where straight quotes are expected)
- Skipped heading levels, thematic breaks (`---`) before every heading
- Vertical lists with a bolded inline header + colon, used as a crutch instead of prose ("**Route Details:** Starts at...")

11. Hollow section summaries

Watch for: "*In summary,*" "*In conclusion,*" "*Overall,*" followed by a restatement of what was just said, adding no new information.

→ Fix: cut. Let the section end on its last substantive point.

12. Uniform sentence rhythm

AI drafts tend to hold sentence length and structure steady across a paragraph: five sentences of 18 to 24 words, each subject-verb-object, each with one subordinate clause. Detectors call this low burstiness. Readers experience it as monotony.

Check: list the sentence lengths in a paragraph. If they all sit within a few words of each other, the rhythm is flat.

→ Fix: let the content set the length. A sentence carrying one fact can be six words. A sentence carrying a chain of reasoning can run long. Merge or split only where the idea itself splits or joins. Don't drop in a short fragment for emphasis on a schedule ("Full stop." "Period." "Simple as that."). A stock punchy line is its own tell.

13. Repeated transitions

The same handful of connectors opening consecutive sentences or paragraphs: *Additionally, Moreover, Furthermore, However, Therefore, In addition, That said, Here's the thing.* One use is fine. The tell is the same few cycling through a page.

→ Fix: often the best transition is none, because the logic is already in the sentences. Where one is needed, use the word that names the real relation (because, but, so, after that). Don't rotate through synonyms just to avoid repeating a word.

14. Sincerity markers and content announcements

Watch for words that claim candor: *genuinely, honestly, truly,* "*here's a direct answer,*" "*the honest takeaway,*" "*to be clear,*" "*the truth is.*" Also openers that announce what the piece will do instead of doing it: "This guide covers all of it," followed by a run of fragments previewing each section ("What X is, precisely. How Y works, not just what the marketing says."), or "If you take one thing from this, make it this."

→ Fix: cut the marker and keep the statement. Replace the preview with the first real point.

15. Abstract business phrasing where an event belongs

Watch for: *gaining traction, streamlining processes, driving results, leveraging, navigating challenges, financial challenges, significant improvements.* These stand in for something that happened to someone.

→ Fix: name the event, number, person or place ("rent was due and I had $500"). If the writer hasn't supplied it, ask. Never invent it.

What NOT to flag (avoid false positives)

These are commonly mistaken for AI tells but are weak or unreliable signals on their own, so don't over-apply this skill:

- Perfect grammar alone
- Formal/academic tone alone
- Any single transition word (Additionally, Moreover) used occasionally
- Unsourced claims alone
- A mix of casual and formal register (often just natural voice)
- A single "not X, but Y" sentence or a single em dash. Both existed in human writing long before ChatGPT. Count them and look at clustering.
- The Oxford comma on its own. It is standard in Chicago, APA and most US house styles, so don't strip it from a writer who uses it consistently. A single list of three items is also fine.

Detection is unreliable. No pattern here proves a text was AI-written, and automated detectors have a poor track record. When reviewing someone's draft, point at the specific sentences that read as generic and say why. Don't tell the writer their work "sounds like AI" as a verdict.

The goal is specific, load-bearing language, not the absence of any polish. A well-written human sentence can use "crucial" once. The tell is *density and clustering* of these patterns together, not any single word.

Keep the rough edges

Uniform polish is itself a signal. Text that is smooth, balanced and coherent in every sentence reads as machine-made, and teachers report getting wary of work that sounds too finished. When editing a person's draft:

- Leave intentional informality, fragments, odd phrasing and uneven rhythm alone. They are part of the voice.
- Don't "fix" a sentence into a more balanced one just because it can be.
- Fix the tells above and leave the person's own quirks in place.
- If a draft has no rough edges at all, say so and ask the writer to add the specific details only they know (names, numbers, what actually happened) instead of adding texture yourself.

Do not fake humanness

Popular "humanize your AI text" advice tells writers to add anecdotes, conversational fillers and quirks, and some of it says invented mock-ups are fine. This skill does not do that.

- No invented anecdotes, numbers, incomes, or scenes (the spilled coffee, the $500 month). Every personal detail comes from the writer. If a spot needs one and none was given, ask, or leave a bracketed gap.
- No scripted casual filler ("Seriously, though?", "yes, I know it sounds a little weird") or rhetorical questions added to seem relaxed.
- No made-up quirky names, deliberate typos, or planted errors.
- Synonym swapping is not editing. Rarer synonyms are themselves a tell and usually make the sentence worse. Rewrite the sentence around its fact, or cut it.
- Fixing rhythm and transitions (items 12 and 13) is fine. The specifics from the writer do most of the work.

How to apply this skill

- **When drafting**: write normally, then run this checklist as a pass before presenting the final version. Actively rewrite flagged phrases rather than just noting them.
- **When reviewing someone else's draft** (e.g., a student essay, a bio, a work document): go through paragraph by paragraph, flag clusters of these patterns, and suggest specific, concrete replacements, not just "this sounds AI-generated."
- Always prioritize *specificity over confidence*: a sentence with one precise fact beats three sentences of generic importance-signaling.
- **Write for the reader, not a detector.** Detectors score perplexity and burstiness, meaning how predictable the words are and how even the sentence lengths are. Formal prose and writing by non-native English speakers can score as "AI" for the same reasons, so a flag is weak evidence. Don't chase a score, don't recommend humanizer tools, and don't promise a text will pass any checker. If a context requires AI-use disclosure (a course, a journal, an application), the writer follows that rule whatever the text looks like.